Philipp Dierker

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Research profile

Family demographer and quantitative sociologist studying how partnership and family dynamics shape health, well-being, and social inequality across the life course. My research combines longitudinal population data, comparative designs, and genetically informed approaches.
Research interests: family demography; population health; social genomics; life-course sociology; intergenerational inequality.

Academic positions

2025–	**Postdoctoral Researcher**, Department of Social Demography, Max Planck Institute for Demographic Research
2026	**Visiting Postdoctoral Research Associate**, Department of Sociology and Office of Population Research, Princeton University (April–July)
2021–2025	**Doctoral Researcher**, Department of Social Demography, Max Planck Institute for Demographic Research

Education

2022–2025	**Ph.D. in Demography**, University of Helsinki, Finland. Thesis: "Partnership dynamics and changes in health and well-being. A bidirectional relationship." Final grade: *pass with distinction*. Supervisor: Prof. Mikko Myrskylä; opponent: Prof. Stefanie Möllborn; external examiners: Prof. Matthijs Kalmijn and Prof. Thomas Leopold.
2019–2021	**M.A. in Sociology**, Bielefeld University, Germany. Final grade: 1.0 (GPA: 4.0).
2015–2019	**B.A. in Politics and Society & History**, University of Bonn, Germany. Final grade: 1.7 (GPA: 3.3).

Publications

Peer-reviewed articles

[1] **Dierker, P.**, Ophir, A., Hiekel, N. (Forthcoming). From dating to marriage: changes in short-term fertility intentions across partnership transitions. *Journal of Marriage and Family*.

[2] **Dierker, P.**, Metsä-Simola, N., Remes, H., Kailaheimo-Lönnqvist, S., Kühn, M., Martikainen, P., Myrskylä, M. (Forthcoming). Parental separation risk before and after the diagnosis of a child physical health condition. *Demography*.

[3] **Dierker, P.**, Kühn, M., Kailaheimo-Lönnqvist, S., Myrskylä, M. (2026). Enduring links: Mental health effects of ex-partner's life events among separated parents. *Social Forces*. doi:10.1093/sf/soag141

[4] **Dierker, P.**, Gueltzow, M., Lahtinen, H., Kühn, M., Martikainen, P., Myrskylä, M. (2026). Do genetics shape mental health trajectories around partnership transitions? *Journal of Marriage and Family*. doi:10.1111/jomf.70088

[5] Sunde, H. F., **Dierker, P.** (2026). Are Spouses Similar in Divorce? Investigating Spousal Similarity in Couple-Shared Outcomes. *Twin Research and Human Genetics*. doi:10.1017/thg.2026.10050

[6] **Dierker, P.**, Kühn, M., Van Winkle, Z. (2026). The Role of Family Complexity in Mental and Physical Health in Mid-Adulthood. *Journal of Marriage and Family*, 88(2), 488–504. doi:10.1111/jomf.70019

[7] Hiilamo, A., Metsä-Simola, N., **Dierker, P.**, Martikainen, P., Myrskylä, M. (2026). Heterogeneous long-term health and social outcomes of type 1 diabetes - A full population 30-year observational cohort study of 38 modifying factors. *American Journal of Epidemiology*, 195(1), 117–125. doi:10.1093/aje/kwaf028

[8] **Dierker, P.**, Kühn, M., Myrskylä, M. (2025). Selective re-partnering? Mental health and life satisfaction among separated single mothers in Germany and the UK. *Acta Sociologica*, 68(3), 1–16. doi:10.1177/00016993241300435

[9] **Dierker, P.**, Kühn, M., Myrskylä, M. (2025). Re-partnering and single mothers' mental health and life satisfaction trajectories. *Journal of Marriage and Family*, 87(1), 157–181. doi:10.1111/jomf.13015

[10] **Dierker, P.**, Diewald, M. (2025). Compensation or accentuation? How parents from different social backgrounds decide to support their children. *European Sociological Review*, 41(1), 111–126. doi:10.1093/esr/jcae010

[11] **Dierker, P.**, Kühn, M., Mönkediek, B. (2023). Does parental separation moderate the heritability of health risk behavior among adolescents? *Social Science & Medicine*, 331, 116070. doi:10.1016/j.socscimed.2023.116070

[12] Gold, J., Störtländer, J., **Dierker, P.**, Textor, A. (2022). Segregation processes in the transition from pre-primary to elementary school. How do inter-district movements change compositions in terms of migration background? [Segregationsprozesse beim Übergang vom Elementarbereich in die Grundschule. Wie verändern Wanderungsbewegungen zwischen den Schulbezirken Kompositionen in Bezug auf Migrationshintergrund?]. *Zeitschrift für Grundschulforschung*, 15, 63–80. doi:10.1007/s42278-021-00128-5

Revise and resubmit

- **Dierker, P.**, Skirbekk, V. Grandparenthood related to reduced risk of gray divorce: evidence from 15 countries. Revise and resubmit at *Social Science Research*. MPIDR Working Paper 2026-015. doi:10.4054/MPIDR-WP-2026-015
- Bister, L., **Dierker, P.** Parental Separation and the Accumulation of Stress during Early Life: A Pubertal Development Marker Approach. Revise and resubmit at *Advances in Life Course Research*. MPIDR Working Paper 2026-002. doi:10.4054/MPIDR-WP-2026-002
- Ruks, M., Starr, A., **Dierker, P.** Investigating the heritability of school grades from age 10 to 16 using biometric growth curve models. Revise and resubmit at *Developmental Psychology*. PsyArXiv preprint. doi:10.31234/osf.io/vecy9
- Bishop, L., **Dierker, P.**, Martikainen, P., Junna, L. Accumulation of sibling complexity and mental health and education among adolescents. Revise and resubmit at *Journal of Marriage and Family*.
- Metsä-Simola, N., **Dierker, P.**, Remes, H., Goisis, A. From pre-pregnancy to early school years: Maternal mental health and ADHD in Germany and the UK. Revise and resubmit at *Advances in Life Course Research*.

Manuscripts under review

- **Dierker, P.** Sibship size and the genetic prediction of education. MPIDR Working Paper 2026-034. doi:10.4054/MPIDR-WP-2026-034
- **Dierker, P.**, Conley, D. Do children's genes evoke educational expectations? Direct genetic effects on parents' and teachers' college encouragement. NBER Working Paper 35576. doi:10.3386/w35576

Awards and fellowships

2026	**Best Paper Award** (€500), German Association for Demography (DGD)
2026	**INVEST Fellowship**, University of Turku, Finland (competitive visiting fellowship)
2023	**Best Poster Award**, IMPRS-PHDS Graduate Workshop, Max Planck Institute for Demographic Research

Invited talks

2026	Biosociology Research Group, Department of Sociology, Princeton University; Office of Population Research, Princeton University
	Institut national d'études démographiques (INED), Paris
2025	Centre for Fertility and Health, Norwegian Institute of Public Health, Oslo
	Max Planck Institute for Human Development, Berlin
	Melbourne Institute of Applied Economic and Social Research, University of Melbourne
	Netherlands Interdisciplinary Demographic Institute, The Hague
2024	Nuffield College, University of Oxford

Conference presentations

2026	*The Advances in Social Genomics Conference* , University of Wisconsin-Madison, United States
	Population Association of America Annual Meeting, St. Louis, United States
2025	*23rd Conference of the European Divorce Network*, Barcelona, Spain
	European Consortium for Sociological Research Annual Conference, Cologne, Germany
	International Population Conference, Brisbane, Australia
	Nordic Demographic Symposium, Middelfart, Denmark
	INVEST Conference, Turku, Finland
	Population Association of America Annual Meeting, Washington D.C., United States
2024	*22nd Conference of the European Divorce Network*, Berlin, Germany
	European Consortium for Sociological Research Annual Conference, Barcelona, Spain
	European Sociological Association Conference, Porto, Portugal
	European Population Conference, Edinburgh, Scotland
	Population Association of America Annual Meeting, Columbus, United States
	Annual Conference 2024 of the German Society for Demography, Hamburg, Germany

2023	*Dutch Demography Day 2023*, Utrecht, Netherlands
	21st Conference of the European Divorce Network, Utrecht, Netherlands
	SLLS Annual International Conference, Munich, Germany
	European Consortium for Sociological Research Annual Conference, Prague, Czech Republic
	Understanding Society Scientific Conference, Colchester, United Kingdom
	RC28 Conference, Paris, France
	European Social Science Genetics Network (ESSGN) Conference, Bologna, Italy
	Population Association of America Annual Meeting, New Orleans, United States
2022	*Deutsche Gesellschaft für Soziologie Kongress*, Bielefeld, Germany
	British Society for Population Studies Annual Conference, Winchester, United Kingdom
	American Sociological Association Annual Meeting, Los Angeles, United States
	European Consortium for Sociological Research Annual Conference, Amsterdam, Netherlands
	European Population Conference 2022, Online
	SOEP User Conference, Berlin, Germany
	Population Association of America Annual Meeting, Atlanta, United States
	Annual Conference 2022 of the German Society for Demography, Online

Research stays

01–03/2027	University of Turku, Finland (INVEST Fellowship; planned; host: Marika Jalovaara)
04–07/2026	Princeton University, United States (host: Dalton Conley)
11/2025	Centre for Fertility and Health, Norwegian Institute of Public Health, Norway (host: Siri Eldevik Håberg)
07/2025	Melbourne Institute of Applied Economic and Social Research, University of Melbourne, Australia (host: Beth Webster)
07/2025	Netherlands Interdisciplinary Demographic Institute, the Netherlands (host: Solveig Cunningham)

Teaching experience

2026/27	**M.A. course, "Causal Inference with Panel Data"**, University of Rostock
2026	**Ph.D. course, "Sociogenomics in Family Demography"**, International Max Planck Research School for Population, Health and Data Science (planned)
2024	**Ph.D. course, "Family Dynamics and Health Inequalities"**, International Max Planck Research School for Population, Health and Data Science
2024	**M.A. seminar, "Intergenerational Relations and Reproductions"** (guest lecture), Tilburg University
2024	**B.A. seminar, "Data Handling for Social Science"**, University of Rostock
2023	**Ph.D. course, "Genetics, Family Dynamics, and Health Inequalities"**, International Max Planck Research School for Population, Health and Data Science
2020–2021	**B.A. tutorials, "Statistics I" and "Statistics II"**, Bielefeld University

Supervision

2026–	**Ph.D. supervisor**, Simon Hirch, Bielefeld University
2025–	**Ph.D. thesis advisory committee member**, Elena Neri, University of Oxford
2024–	**Ph.D. thesis advisory committee member**, Lotta Volotinen, University of Helsinki

Selected research training

2024	**Using genetics to understand social structures: Genetic influences across time, groups, and societies**, University of Oslo
2023	**Sociogenomics workshop**, Finnish Institute for Health and Welfare
	Decomposition Methods in the Social Sciences, GESIS Spring Seminar 2023 - Modeling Group Differences (Cologne)
2022	**Sequence Analysis in the Social Sciences**, GESIS Workshops (Online)
	Advanced Methods for Causal Inference, International Max Planck Research School for Population, Health, and Data Science
	From decomposition to causal mediation analysis: a multidisciplinary perspective, International Max Planck Research School for Population, Health, and Data Science
	Mendelian Randomization, International Max Planck Research School for Population, Health, and Data Science

Academic service

Journal refereeing

Acta Sociologica; Advances in Life Course Research; BMC Public Health; Demographic Research; European Child & Adolescent Psychiatry; European Journal of Population; European Societies; European Sociological Review; Family Transitions; Journal of Family Studies; Journal of Health and Social Behavior; Journal of Marriage and Family; Population Studies; Scientific Reports; Social Forces; Social Indicators Research; Social Science Research; Socius.

Other service

2025–	**Organizer**, Lab Talk seminar series, Department of Social Demography, Max Planck Institute for Demographic Research
2025–	**Organizer**, BIOSFER Scientific Talk series, ERC Synergy Grant BIOSFER
2025	**Reviewing committee member**, European Doctoral School of Demography, 2025/2026 cohort
2022–	**Elected member of the works council**, Max Planck Institute for Demographic Research

Affiliations and memberships

– Max Planck–University of Helsinki Center for Social Inequalities in Population Health; FLUX consortium; INVEST Research Flagship Centre.
– Population Association of America; European Association for Population Studies; ISA RC28; Sections of Health and Medical Sociology and Family Sociology of the German Sociological Association.

References

Prof. Mikko Myrskylä
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